

Absolutely — **stretch** is a very strong polysemy target because your passage uses it figuratively here:

> “They may care about roadside pollution, yet choose a cheaper petrol car if an electric model **stretches** their mortgage budget...”

Here **stretch** means **to put financial resources under strain by requiring them to cover more than is comfortable or easy**.

Word family: **stretch / stretched / stretchy / stretching**

Base verb: stretch

Base noun: stretch

Adjective/participle: stretched

Adjective: stretchy

Gerund/noun: stretching

Part of speech: verb (動詞) / noun (名詞) / adjective (形容詞)

Major domains:

- * physical extension
- * body movement/exercise
- * elastic materials
- * distance/area
- * periods of time
- * financial resources/budgets
- * capacity/resources
- * truth/credibility
- * effort/ability
- * imprisonment slang
- * roads/rivers
- * final stages of races/projects
- * fixed expressions such as **at a stretch**, **by any stretch of the imagination**, **stretch your legs**, **home stretch**

Meaning in your passage: **stretch a budget** = strain financial resources — 令預算吃緊；使財政負擔加重

Your sentence:

> “if an electric model **stretches** their mortgage budget...”

means:

> **if buying the electric car would require the household budget to cover more than it comfortably can, especially while the family is already paying a mortgage.**

繁體中文：

令家庭財政預算變得吃緊、逼近可負擔上限；使原本有限的資金需要勉強應付更多開支

Natural translation:

> 「如果某款電動車會令他們在供樓之餘的家庭預算變得**十分吃緊**，他們仍可能選擇較便宜的汽油車。」

So here:

> **stretch = 把有限資源逼近極限，使其勉強足以應付需要**

A. PHYSICALLY MAKE LONGER / WIDER

1. **stretch something = pull something so it becomes longer/wider — 拉長；拉伸；撐開**

The core physical sense.

Practice 1

> “Do not **stretch** the cable too tightly.”

「不要把電線**拉得太緊 / 拉伸過度**。」

Practice 2

> “She stretched the fabric across the frame.”

「她把布料**拉開鋪在框架上**。」

stretch = 對某物施力，使其在長度、寬度或形狀上延伸

B. MATERIAL STRETCHES

2. **stretch = become longer/wider when pulled — 伸展；拉開；有彈性地延伸**

Practice 3

> “This material ****stretches**** easily.”

「這種材料很容易****拉伸****。」

Practice 4

> “The waistband stretches when you move.”

「你活動時，腰帶會****伸展****。」

Here the object itself changes shape.

C. STRETCHY

3. ****stretchy = elastic / able to stretch — 有彈性的；可拉伸的****

Practice 5

> “The trousers are made from ****stretchy**** fabric.”

「這條褲子使用****彈性布料****製成。」

Practice 6

> “Stretchy materials are comfortable for exercise.”

「****有彈性的材料****適合做運動時穿著。」

****stretchy = 能夠被拉長 / 拉寬並通常恢復原狀的****

D. STRETCH OUT YOUR BODY

4. ****stretch = extend arms/legs/body — 伸展身體；伸手；伸腿****

Practice 7

> “She ****stretched**** her arms above her head.”

「她把雙臂****伸到頭頂上方****。」

Practice 8

> “He stretched his legs after sitting for hours.”

「坐了幾小時後，他**伸展了一下雙腿**。」

E. STRETCH — EXERCISE

5. **stretch = perform an exercise that lengthens muscles — 拉筋；伸展**

Practice 9

> “Always **stretch** before intense exercise.”

「做劇烈運動前要先**拉筋 / 伸展**。」

Practice 10

> “She stretched for ten minutes after running.”

「跑步後她做了十分鐘**伸展運動**。」

F. A STRETCH — EXERCISE

6. **a stretch = stretching movement/exercise — 伸展動作；拉筋動作**

Practice 11

> “This is a good **stretch** for your back.”

「這是一個很好的背部**伸展動作**。」

Practice 12

> “Hold the stretch for twenty seconds.”

「保持這個**拉筋姿勢**二十秒。」

G. STRETCH YOUR LEGS

7. **stretch your legs = 伸伸腿；起來走動一下**

A common fixed expression.

Practice 13

> “Let’s stop and **stretch our legs**.”

「我們停下來**伸伸腿、走動一下**吧。」

Practice 14

> “Passengers got off the bus to stretch their legs.”

「乘客下車**活動一下雙腿**。」

Often means:

> walk around briefly after sitting.

H. STRETCH ACROSS / ALONG

8. **stretch = extend over a large area/distance — 延伸；綿延**

A major intransitive sense.

Practice 15

> “The road **stretches** along the coast.”

「道路沿海岸**綿延**。」

Practice 16

> “The city stretches for kilometres in every direction.”

「這座城市向四面八方**延伸數公里**。」

stretch = 某地形 / 物體本身延續到很遠的地方

I. STRETCH FROM A TO B

9. **stretch from A to B = 從 A 延伸至 B**

Practice 17

> “The highway stretches from the city to the border.”

「高速公路從城市**延伸到邊境**。」

Practice 18

> “The park stretches from the river to the hills.”

「公園從河邊一路**延伸到山丘**。」

J. A STRETCH OF ROAD / LAND / WATER

10. **stretch = continuous length/area — 一段；一片；一長段**

A major noun sense.

Practice 19

> “This **stretch of road** is dangerous.”

「這**一段道路**很危險。」

Practice 20

> “They walked along a quiet stretch of beach.”

「他們沿著一段寧靜的**海灘**散步。」

a stretch of X = 某個連續延伸的一段地方 / 區域

K. STRETCH OF RIVER

11. **a stretch of river = 一段河流**

Practice 21

> “This stretch of river is polluted.”

「這**一段河流**受到污染。」

Practice 22

> “The bridge crosses a wide stretch of water.”

「橋樑跨過一大片**水域**。」

L. STRETCH OF COAST

12. **stretch of coast = 一段海岸**

Practice 23

> “The road follows a beautiful stretch of coast.”

「道路沿著一段美麗的**海岸線**。」

Practice 24

> “This stretch of coastline is protected.”

「這一段**海岸線**受到保護。」

M. A STRETCH OF TIME

13. **stretch = continuous period of time — 一段時間**

A major noun sense.

Practice 25

> “He worked for a long **stretch** without a break.”

「他連續工作了很長**一段時間**都沒有休息。」

Practice 26

> “The dry stretch lasted several weeks.”

「這段**持續乾旱期**維持了數星期。」

****stretch = 一段沒有明顯中斷的連續時間****

N. LONG STRETCH

14. **a long stretch = 很長一段時間 / 距離**

Practice 27

> “She drove for a long stretch.”

「她連續駕車很長**一段路 / 時間**。」

Practice 28

> “There was a long stretch of silence.”

「有一大段時間大家都**沉默不語**。」

Context decides:

* distance

* time

O. AT A STRETCH

15. **at a stretch = 連續地 ; 一口氣**

A major fixed expression.

Practice 29

> “He can work for six hours **at a stretch**.”

「他可以**一口氣 / 連續**工作六小時。」

Practice 30

> “The car can travel hundreds of kilometres at a stretch.”

「這輛車可以**一次連續**行駛數百公里。」

at a stretch = without stopping/interruption

P. STRETCH A BUDGET

16. **stretch a budget = 令預算勉強足夠 / 使預算吃緊**

This is your exact source branch.

Practice 31 — Passage sense

> “The electric model would **stretch their mortgage budget**.”

「這款電動車會令他們供樓之外的家庭**預算變得很吃緊**。」

Practice 32

> “Higher insurance costs could stretch the family budget.”

「較高的保險費可能會令家庭**財政變得吃緊**。」

stretch a budget = 要求有限預算負擔更多開支，逼近可負擔上限

Q. STRETCH YOUR MONEY

17. **stretch your money = 令有限金錢用得更久 / 更抵用**

Closely related but slightly different emphasis.

Practice 33

> “Buying second-hand can help **stretch your money**.”

「買二手貨可以讓有限的錢**用得更久 / 更抵使**。」

Practice 34

> “Careful planning helps families stretch their income.”

「審慎規劃可以讓家庭的收入**更耐用、更足以應付開支**。」

Here **stretch** means:

> make limited resources cover more.

R. STRETCH RESOURCES

18. **stretch resources = 令資源吃緊；使有限資源勉強應付更多需要**

Practice 35

> “The sudden demand **stretched hospital resources**.”

「突然增加的需求令醫院資源**非常吃緊**。」

Practice 36

> “Rapid expansion stretched the company’s staff and finances.”

「快速擴張令公司的員工和財政資源都**承受很大壓力**。」

S. STRETCHED RESOURCES

19. **stretched = under heavy pressure because resources are limited — 資源緊絀的；負荷過重的**

Practice 37

> “Emergency services are already **stretched**.”

「緊急服務的資源已經**非常緊張 / 負荷很重**。」

Practice 38

> “The team is stretched because several employees are absent.”

「由於多名員工缺勤，團隊目前**人手十分緊張**。」

T. STRETCHED THIN

20. **stretched thin = 人力 / 資源被攤得太薄；疲於應付**

A very common expression.

Practice 39

> “The department is ****stretched thin****.”

「這個部門****人手和資源都十分吃緊****。」

Practice 40

> “Working on five projects at once left her stretched thin.”

「同時處理五個項目令她****疲於奔命、分身乏術****。」

Core metaphor:

> limited resources spread over too many demands.

U. STRETCH CAPACITY

21. ****stretch capacity = 逼近 / 超出處理能力****

Practice 41

> “Peak demand stretched the charging network’s capacity.”

「高峰需求令充電網絡的****容量逼近極限****。」

Practice 42

> “The workload stretched the system to its limits.”

「工作量令系統的****處理能力逼近極限****。」

V. STRETCH TO THE LIMIT

22. ****stretch something to the limit = 把……逼到極限****

Practice 43

> “The emergency stretched staff to the limit.”

「這次緊急事件令員工****幾乎到達負荷極限****。」

Practice 44

> “The extra cost stretched their finances to the limit.”

「額外開支令他們的財政**逼近極限**。」

W. STRETCH SOMEONE FINANCIALLY

23. **stretch someone financially = 令某人財政吃緊**

Practice 45

> “The mortgage has stretched them financially.”

「按揭令他們的**財政非常吃緊**。」

Practice 46

> “A more expensive car would stretch the family financially.”

「買更昂貴的汽車會令家庭**財政負擔很重**。」

X. STRETCH AN INCOME

24. **stretch an income = 讓有限收入應付更多支出**

Practice 47

> “Families are trying to stretch their incomes.”

「家庭正設法讓有限收入**應付更多開支**。」

Practice 48

> “Rising prices make it harder to stretch a monthly salary.”

「物價上升令一份月薪更難**撐足整個月**。」

Y. STRETCH FOOD / SUPPLIES

25. **stretch supplies = 讓有限物資維持更久 / 供更多人使用**

Practice 49

> “They added vegetables to stretch the meal.”

「他們加入更多蔬菜，令這餐飯**足夠更多人吃**。」

Practice 50

> “The shelter had to stretch its supplies for another week.”

「收容所必須讓有限物資**再撐一星期**。」

This is the same resource-extension metaphor.

Z. STRETCH ABILITY / SKILL

26. **stretch someone = challenge someone beyond their usual level — 挑戰；逼使發揮更高能力**

A major figurative sense.

Practice 51

> “The assignment really **stretched** me.”

「這份作業真的很**考驗我的能力**。」

Practice 52

> “Good teachers stretch their students.”

「好的老師會**挑戰學生，促使他們提升能力**。」

stretch someone = 要求某人超越平常舒適 / 能力範圍

AA. STRETCH YOURSELF

27. **stretch yourself = 挑戰自己；突破自己的能力範圍**

Practice 53

> “Try to **stretch yourself** with a more difficult task.”

「試著用更困難的任務來**挑戰自己**。」

Practice 54

> “She wanted a job that would stretch her.”

「她想要一份能夠**挑戰自己能力**的工作。」

AB. STRETCHING ASSIGNMENT

28. **stretching task/assignment = 具挑戰性、能拓展能力的任務**

Practice 55

> “The course includes several stretching assignments.”

「課程包括幾項**很有挑戰、能提升能力的作業**。」

Practice 56

> “A stretching role can accelerate professional growth.”

「一個具挑戰性的職位可以加快專業成長。」

Especially BrE/business.

AC. STRETCH GOAL

29. **stretch goal = 挑戰性目標；高難度目標**

A major workplace/business compound.

Practice 57

> “The team set a **stretch goal** for sales.”

「團隊訂立了一個**具挑戰性的銷售目標**。」

Practice 58

> “Stretch goals should be ambitious but not impossible.”

「挑戰性目標應該有野心，但不應完全不可能達成。」

****stretch goal = 刻意訂得高於一般預期，以迫使團隊提升表現的目標****

AD. STRETCH TARGET

30. ****stretch target = 挑戰性指標 / 高目標****

Especially BrE/business.

Practice 59

> “Management introduced a stretch target.”

「管理層設定了一個****高挑戰性目標****。」

Practice 60

> “The stretch target encouraged the team to rethink its approach.”

「高挑戰性目標促使團隊重新思考方法。」

AE. STRETCH THE TRUTH

31. ****stretch the truth = 誇大事實；把真相說得過頭****

A major idiom.

Practice 61

> “He was ****stretching the truth**** about the car’s condition.”

「他對車況的描述有點****誇大其詞****。」

Practice 62

> “Advertising can sometimes stretch the truth.”

「廣告有時會****誇大事實****。」

****stretch the truth = 沒有完全說謊，但把事實誇大 / 扭曲到超出正常範圍****

AF. STRETCH CREDIBILITY

32. **stretch credibility = 令人難以相信；超出可信範圍**

Practice 63

> “The explanation **stretches credibility**.”

「這個解釋**實在令人難以相信**。」

Practice 64

> “Claiming the battery will last forever stretches credibility.”

「聲稱電池永遠不會壞，實在**超出可信範圍**。」

stretch credibility = 要求人相信過於牽強的說法

AG. STRETCH BELIEF

33. **stretch belief = 令人難以置信**

Practice 65

> “The coincidence stretches belief.”

「這個巧合實在**令人難以置信**。」

Practice 66

> “Some parts of the story stretch belief.”

「故事某些部分**太牽強，令人難以相信**。」

Less common than:

> stretch credibility.

AH. “THAT’S A STRETCH”

34. **that's a stretch = 那說法太牽強了；那有點勉強**

A major conversational use.

Practice 67

> “Calling this tiny improvement a revolution is **a stretch**.”

「把這麼小的改進稱作革命，實在有點**牽強**。」

Practice 68

> “Saying the car is completely risk-free would be a stretch.”

「說這輛車完全沒有風險就有點**說得太過了**。」

a stretch = interpretation/claim that goes beyond what the evidence comfortably supports

AI. “NOT MUCH OF A STRETCH”

35. **not much of a stretch = 並不算牽強；很容易推想到**

Practice 69

> “It is not much of a stretch to say that convenience affects adoption.”

「說便利性會影響普及程度，**並不算牽強**。」

Practice 70

> “Given the evidence, that conclusion is not much of a stretch.”

「考慮到這些證據，那個結論**不算太勉強**。」

AJ. BY ANY STRETCH OF THE IMAGINATION

36. **by any stretch of the imagination = 無論怎樣想像；怎樣都稱不上**

A major idiom.

Practice 71

> “The car is not cheap ****by any stretch of the imagination****.”

「無論怎樣說，這輛車都****絕對稱不上便宜****。」

Practice 72

> “This is not a minor problem by any stretch of the imagination.”

「這個問題****怎樣都不能算是小問題****。」

Usually used with negatives:

> not X by any stretch of the imagination

= 絕對稱不上 X.

AK. STRETCH THE MEANING / DEFINITION

37. ****stretch a definition = 把定義延伸得過闊；勉強套用****

Practice 73

> “That interpretation stretches the definition of ‘affordable’.”

「那種解讀把『負擔得起』的定義****拉得太闊 / 勉強套用****。」

Practice 74

> “We should not stretch the term beyond its usual meaning.”

「我們不應把這個詞的意思****過度延伸****。」

AL. STRETCH A RULE

38. ****stretch the rules = 把規則放寬到極限；鑽規則空間****

Practice 75

> “The company was accused of stretching the rules.”

「公司被指****把規則解釋得過度寬鬆 / 踩界****。」

Practice 76

> “There is a difference between interpreting a rule and stretching it.”

「合理解釋規則與**把規則拉到極限**是兩回事。」

AM. STRETCH AN ANALOGY

39. **stretch an analogy/comparison = 把類比拉得太遠；過度延伸類比**

Practice 77

> “The analogy works at first, but the author stretches it too far.”

「這個類比最初成立，但作者後來**延伸得太過頭**。」

Practice 78

> “We should not stretch the comparison.”

「我們不應把這個比較**硬套得太遠**。」

AN. STRETCH TIME / DEADLINE

40. **stretch a period/deadline = 延長；拉長時間**

Practice 79

> “The project stretched over three years.”

「這個項目**延續了三年**。」

Practice 80

> “Delays stretched the schedule by several months.”

「延誤令時間表**拉長了幾個月**。」

This belongs to temporal extension.

AO. STRETCH INTO / OVER

41. **stretch into/over + time = 延續到..... / 持續.....**

Practice 81

> “The negotiations stretched into the night.”

「談判**一直持續到晚上**。」

Practice 82

> “The repair work stretched over several weeks.”

「維修工作**持續了數星期**。」

AP. STRETCH = LAST / EXTEND SUPPLIES

42. **make something stretch = 讓某物勉強夠用**

Practice 83

> “We have to make the budget **stretch** until the end of the month.”

「我們要設法讓預算**撐到月底**。」

Practice 84

> “She made the food stretch for two extra guests.”

「她設法讓食物**多供兩位客人享用**。」

Very useful everyday resource sense.

AQ. CAN'T STRETCH TO + PRICE

43. **cannot stretch to + amount/item = 負擔不起較高金額**

Especially BrE.

Practice 85

> “We can’t quite **stretch to** the more expensive model.”

「我們的預算還是**負擔不起**較貴的型號。」

Practice 86

> “Their budget would not stretch to a private garage.”

「他們的預算**不足以負擔**私人車房。」

This is very close to the source meaning.

AR. BUDGET WON'T STRETCH THAT FAR

44. **budget won't stretch that far** = 預算負擔不到那個程度

Practice 87

> “Our budget **won't stretch that far**.”

「我們的預算**實在撐不到那麼高**。」

Practice 88

> “I would like the larger battery, but my budget will not stretch that far.”

「我想要較大的電池，但我的預算**負擔不起那麼高的價格**。」

AS. STRETCH = IMPRISONMENT TERM

45. **a stretch** = 一段刑期

Informal/slang, but established.

Practice 89

> “He served a five-year **stretch** in prison.”

「他服了**五年刑期**。」

Practice 90

> “After a long stretch inside, he returned home.”

「服完一段長**刑期**後，他回到家中。」

Register:

* informal

* slang

* crime/journalistic

Lower priority but genuinely distinct.

AT. HOME STRETCH

46. **home stretch = 最後階段；最後一段路程**

Originally racing; now widely figurative.

Practice 91

> “The project is in the **home stretch**.”

「這個項目已進入**最後階段**。」

Practice 92

> “We are in the home stretch of the semester.”

「這個學期已進入**最後階段**。」

home stretch = 接近終點的最後一段

AU. FINAL STRETCH

47. **final stretch = 最後一段；最後階段**

Practice 93

> “The runners entered the final stretch.”

「跑手進入**最後一段賽道**。」

Practice 94

> “The negotiations are in the final stretch.”

「談判已進入**最後階段**。」

AV. DOWN THE STRETCH

48. **down the stretch = 在最後階段**

Especially AmE sports/journalism.

Practice 95

> “The team played well **down the stretch**.”

「球隊在**比賽最後階段**表現很好。」

Practice 96

> “Demand improved down the stretch of the year.”

「到了年尾的**最後階段**，需求有所改善。」

Less central than:

> home stretch / final stretch.

AW. STRETCH LIMOUSINE

49. **stretch limousine / stretch limo = 加長型豪華轎車**

A lexicalized compound.

Practice 97

> “They arrived in a stretch limousine.”

「他們乘坐**加長型豪華轎車**到場。」

Practice 98

> “A stretch limo has an extended body.”

「加長型豪華轎車的車身經過**加長**。」

Here **stretch** means:

> physically lengthened beyond standard model.

AX. STRETCH FABRIC

50. **stretch fabric = 彈性布料**

Practice 99

> “The jacket uses stretch fabric.”

「這件外套使用**彈性布料**。」

Practice 100

> “Stretch fabric allows greater movement.”

「彈性布料讓身體活動更自如。」

AY. STRETCH MARKS

51. **stretch marks = 妊娠紋 / 伸展紋**

A major fixed compound.

Practice 101

> “Stretch marks can appear when skin stretches rapidly.”

「皮膚快速拉伸時可能出現**伸展紋**。」

Practice 102

> “Stretch marks are common during periods of rapid body growth.”

「身體快速增長期間出現伸展紋很常見。」

AZ. STRETCH REFLEX

52. **stretch reflex = 牽張反射**

Medical/physiology.

Practice 103

> “The stretch reflex helps regulate muscle length.”

「**牽張反射**有助調節肌肉長度。」

Practice 104

> “Doctors can test certain reflex responses.”

「醫生可以測試某些反射反應。」

Specialist but established.

BA. STRETCHING — EXERCISE NOUN

53. **stretching = 伸展運動；拉筋**

Practice 105

> “Regular stretching can improve flexibility.”

「定期做**伸展運動**可以改善柔韌度。」

Practice 106

> “The session begins with stretching.”

「課堂以**拉筋 / 伸展**開始。」

BB. STRETCHED — PHYSICALLY EXTENDED

54. **stretched = 被拉長 / 繃緊的**

Practice 107

> “The cable was stretched too tightly.”

「電線被**拉得太緊**。」

Practice 108

> “The fabric remained stretched.”

「布料保持在**拉伸狀態**。」

BC. STRETCHED — RESOURCES UNDER PRESSURE

55. **stretched = resources/person under excessive demand — 吃緊的；不勝負荷的**

Practice 109

> “The hospital is severely stretched.”

「醫院目前**資源嚴重吃緊**。」

Practice 110

> “Staff are stretched during peak periods.”

「高峰期員工會**工作負荷過重**。」

This is one of the most important adjective extensions.

BD. STRETCH VS EXTEND

56. **stretch vs extend**

stretch

= lengthen physically, or extend under tension/pressure.

extend

= make something longer in space/time/scope, usually neutral.

Compare:

> stretch elastic

> = 拉伸橡筋

> extend deadline

> = 延長期限

****Stretch**** often suggests:

* tension

* strain

* reaching beyond normal extent.

BE. STRETCH VS LENGTHEN

****lengthen****

= make longer.

****stretch****

= make longer by pulling / make something cover more.

> lengthen road? possible in planning

> stretch rope = physically pull

****Stretch**** is more vivid/physical.

BF. STRETCH VS EXPAND

****expand****

= become larger in size, scope, volume.

****stretch****

= extend mainly in length/coverage or under strain.

A company:

> expands operations

A budget:

> stretches to cover more.

BG. STRETCH VS SPREAD

spread

= extend/distribute across area.

stretch

= extend continuously across distance.

> forest spreads across region

> road stretches across region

Different spatial image.

BH. STRETCH VS STRAIN

57. **stretch vs strain**

stretch

= extend beyond ordinary length/capacity.

strain

= place excessive pressure on something, possibly causing difficulty/damage.

In finance:

> "The purchase would stretch the budget."

> = 預算會很吃緊

> "The purchase would strain the household finances."

> = 對家庭財政造成很大壓力

****Strain**** is generally more negative/severe.

BI. STRETCH VS SQUEEZE — BUDGET

You previously curated ****squeeze****.

****stretch a budget****

= make limited money cover more / push budget close to limit.

****squeeze a budget****

= reduce available room/resources or force cuts.

> higher cost stretches the budget

> falling income squeezes the budget

Close, but different metaphor.

BJ. STRETCH VS BREAK THE BUDGET

****stretch the budget****

= difficult but potentially still manageable.

****break/blow the budget****

= exceed the budget.

This distinction is extremely important for your source.

If an EV:

> stretches their budget

it may still be technically affordable.

If it:

> blows the budget

it is beyond the planned limit.

BK. STRETCH VS EXCEED

stretch a limit

= push close to or slightly beyond normal tolerance.

exceed a limit

= objectively go beyond the stated limit.

So:

- > stretched budget
- > does not necessarily mean
- > budget exceeded.

BL. STRETCH VS AFFORD

afford

= have enough money/resources to pay.

stretch

= make limited money/resources reach far enough.

A family may technically:

- > afford a car

but only by:

- > stretching its budget.

Excellent passage distinction.

BM. STRETCH VS SAVE

save money

= keep/spend less.

stretch money

= make the same amount cover more needs.

Different financial strategies.

BN. STRETCH VS ECONOMISE

economise

= reduce spending/use.

stretch resources

= make limited resources last/cover more.

Economising can help you stretch a budget.

BO. STRETCH VS CHALLENGE — ABILITY

challenge someone

= give them something difficult.

stretch someone

= specifically push their abilities beyond normal comfort level.

A task can be:

> challenging

without necessarily:

> stretching someone significantly.

BP. STRETCH VS OVERWHELM

You already curated ****overwhelm****.

****stretch someone****

= test abilities/resources strongly.

****overwhelm someone****

= demands become too great to cope with.

Scale roughly:

> comfortable → stretched → overwhelmed

Not a rigid scale, but useful.

BQ. STRETCH VS EXAGGERATE

****exaggerate****

= make something seem greater than it is.

****stretch the truth****

= idiom meaning exaggerate/distort truth.

So:

> stretch alone does not generally mean exaggerate.

That meaning appears especially in:

> stretch the truth

> stretch credibility

> a stretch.

BR. A STRETCH VS LIE

****a stretch****

= claim/interpretation somewhat too far from evidence.

lie

= deliberate false statement.

Calling something:

> “a stretch”

is much softer than:

> “a lie.”

BS. STRETCH THE TRUTH VS LIE

stretch the truth

= exaggerate or distort without necessarily inventing everything.

lie

= knowingly state something false.

This distinction is very useful.

BT. STRETCH VS FLEXIBILITY

stretch

= action/ability to extend.

flexibility

= ability to bend/move through range.

Muscles can:

> be stretched

and regular stretching can:

> improve flexibility.

Not synonyms.

BU. STRETCHY VS ELASTIC

58. **stretchy vs elastic**

stretchy

= everyday: easily stretches.

elastic

= material property of deforming and returning toward original shape.

> stretchy shirt

> = informal/everyday

> elastic material

> = more technical/general

BV. STRETCH VS REACH

stretch your arm

= extend arm, often toward something.

reach

= successfully extend far enough to touch/get something.

You may:

> stretch toward something

without:

> reaching it.

BW. STRETCH VS LEAN

stretch

= extend body/limbs.

lean

= incline body/object.

A person may lean forward without stretching.

BX. STRETCH VS YAWN

Morning behaviour often combines:

> yawn and stretch

But:

* yawn = involuntary mouth/breath response

* stretch = extend muscles/body

Different.

BY. STRETCH — RANGE / LIMIT METAPHOR

A large number of abstract uses share one core metaphor:

> **something has a normal range/capacity, and stretch pushes it farther**

Examples:

* stretch a budget

* stretch resources

* stretch ability

* stretch credibility

* stretch definition

* stretch rules

* stretch deadline

This is the most useful conceptual key for remembering the word.

BZ. STRETCH — POSITIVE VS NEGATIVE

The word itself is not always negative.

Positive:

> “This role will stretch you.”

= 挑戰你、令你成長

Neutral:

> “The road stretches for ten kilometres.”

= 延伸十公里

Negative:

> “The hospital is stretched.”

= 資源吃緊

Doubtful:

> “That explanation is a stretch.”

= 解釋太牽強

Context controls evaluation.

CA. SOURCE-SPECIFIC “MORTGAGE BUDGET”

Your phrase:

> “stretches their mortgage budget”

is slightly compressed stylistically.

It means roughly:

> **their household finances are already committed to mortgage payments, and the more expensive EV would push the remaining budget close to its affordable limit.**

So ****mortgage budget**** here does not necessarily mean:

> a separate formal account called a mortgage budget.

Rather:

> a household budget already constrained by mortgage payments.

Natural Chinese should therefore avoid an overly literal translation.

Best rendering:

> ****「令供樓家庭的財政預算變得吃緊」****

rather than:

> 「拉長他們的按揭預算」 

CB. CORE SEMANTIC MAP

The broad core is:

> ****extend something beyond its ordinary size, range, duration, or capacity****

From this come:

physical

> stretch a rope

body

> stretch your legs

space

> road stretches north

time

> work for a long stretch

money

> stretch a budget

resources

> hospital resources are stretched

ability

> task stretches students

truth

> stretch the truth

credibility

> that's a stretch

final distance

> home stretch

This is a beautifully coherent polysemy network.

CC. PRONUNCIATION

****stretch**** /stretʃ/

****stretched**** /stretʃt/

****stretching**** /'stretʃɪŋ/

****stretchy**** /'stretʃi/

Spelling:

> stretch → stretched

> stretch → stretching

> stretch → stretchy

CD. FAMILY-EXTENSION SWEEP

Following the fullest-reference style, the useful modern inventory includes:

* ****stretch — physical transitive**** = 拉長 / 拉伸

* **stretch — material intransitive** = 有彈性地伸展
* **stretch your body** = 伸展身體
* **stretching** = 拉筋 / 伸展運動
* **a stretch — exercise** = 伸展動作
* **stretch your legs** = 伸腿 / 走動一下
* **stretch across/along** = 延伸 / 綿延
* **stretch from A to B** = 從 A 延伸到 B
* **a stretch of road** = 一段道路
* **a stretch of land/coast/river** = 一片 / 一段土地、海岸、河流
* **a stretch of time** = 一段連續時間
* **at a stretch** = 連續地 / 一口氣
* **stretch a budget** = 令預算吃緊 / 讓預算勉強足夠
* **stretch your money** = 讓有限金錢用得久
* **stretch an income** = 讓有限收入應付更多支出
* **stretch resources** = 令資源吃緊
* **stretched resources** = 資源緊絀
* **stretched thin** = 分身乏術 / 資源攤得太薄
* **stretch capacity** = 逼近處理能力極限
* **stretch someone financially** = 令某人財政吃緊
* **stretch someone's ability** = 挑戰某人的能力
* **stretch yourself** = 挑戰自己
* **stretch goal** = 挑戰性目標
* **stretch target** = 高挑戰性指標
* **stretch the truth** = 誇大事實
* **stretch credibility** = 超出可信範圍
* **a stretch** = 牽強的說法 / 推論
* **by any stretch of the imagination** = 無論如何都稱不上
* **stretch a definition** = 把定義延伸得過闊
* **stretch the rules** = 把規則解釋得過度寬鬆
* **stretch over/into time** = 延續到 / 持續
* **make something stretch** = 讓有限資源勉強夠用
* **cannot stretch to** = 預算不足以負擔
* **a stretch — prison** = 一段刑期
* **home stretch** = 最後階段
* **final stretch** = 最後一段 / 最後階段
* **stretch limousine** = 加長型豪華轎車
* **stretch fabric** = 彈性布料
* **stretch marks** = 伸展紋
* **stretchy** = 有彈性的
* **stretched — resources** = 不勝負荷 / 資源吃緊的

Master comparison

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stretch — physical	用拉力使物件變得更長、更闊或繃緊	
stretch — body	把手腳 / 肌肉伸展開來	
stretching	為增加活動幅度 / 放鬆肌肉而進行的伸展運動	
stretch — spatial	在空間上連續延伸至很遠的地方	
a stretch of road/land	一段連續延伸的道路 / 土地 / 水域	
a stretch of time	一段沒有明顯中斷的連續時間	
at a stretch	不停頓地連續一段時間	
stretch a budget	令有限預算需要勉強負擔更多開支，逼近可承受上限	
stretch money/resources	令有限金錢 / 資源維持更久或供更多用途	
stretched resources	因需求太大而資源緊絀、不勝負荷的	
stretched thin	因同時承擔太多事情而人手 / 精力 / 資源不足	
stretch someone	挑戰某人的能力，使其超越平常舒適範圍	
stretch goal	刻意設定得高於一般預期、用來推動更高表現的目標	
stretch the truth	把事實誇大或扭曲，但未必完全捏造	
stretch credibility	要求人相信一個過於牽強、難以置信的說法	
a stretch — figurative	與證據 / 合理解讀距離太遠的牽強說法	
by any stretch of the imagination	無論如何想像都無法合理稱為某事	
cannot stretch to X	預算 / 資源不足以負擔 X	
a stretch — prison	非正式指一段監禁刑期	
home/final stretch	接近終點的最後一段；比喻工作 / 項目的最後階段	
stretchy	能被拉伸、通常又具有彈性的	

For your original sentence

> “They may care about roadside pollution, yet choose a cheaper petrol car if an electric model
****stretches their mortgage budget****...”

The exact meaning is:

****stretch = 購買較昂貴的電動車會令這個已經要負擔按揭供款的家庭，把有限收入和預算推到接近可負擔極限；未必完全買不起，但會令家庭財政非常吃緊。****

Natural translation:

> ****「他們可能很關心路邊污染，但如果某款電動車會令一個本來已要供樓的家庭財政變得十分吃緊，他們仍可能選擇較便宜的汽油車。」****

The highest-value contrasts are:

- > ****stretch a rope**** → 拉長繩子
- > ****stretch your legs**** → 伸腿 / 走動一下
- > ****road stretches north**** → 道路向北延伸
- > ****a stretch of road**** → 一段道路
- > ****at a stretch**** → 一口氣 / 連續地
- > ****stretch a budget**** → 令預算吃緊

- > ****stretch your money**** → 讓有限金錢更耐用
- > ****stretched resources**** → 資源緊絀
- > ****stretched thin**** → 分身乏術 / 資源過度分散
- > ****stretch someone**** → 挑戰某人能力
- > ****stretch goal**** → 挑戰性目標
- > ****stretch the truth**** → 誇大事實
- > ****that's a stretch**** → 那說法太牽強
- > ****home stretch**** → 最後階段
- > ****stretch ≠ strain**** → 逼近能力 / 資源上限 ≠ 對其造成更強烈壓力或損害
- > ****stretch a budget ≠ exceed a budget**** → 預算變吃緊 ≠ 已經超支
- > ****stretch a budget ≠ afford comfortably**** → 技術上可能仍負擔得起，但會很勉強